

St Brides Church

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THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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St Bride's church, known as the Journalists' church and, before that, the Printers' church, has a history stretching back almost 2000 years.

In the crypts can be seen the exposed foundations of the seven buildings before the present church, from the 6th Century through to the 11th and 15th Century Medieval buildings, along with a section of Roman tessellated paving and artefacts from AD 180.

Enter and be amazed by the contrast of the Portland stone exterior to the bright interior, flooded with natural light. Escape the noise and busyness of Fleet Street to this sanctuary of quiet and calm.

The present church, designed by Sir Christopher Wren, was completed in 1675 following the loss of the medieval church in the Great Fire of London in 1666. Disaster struck again in the Blitz of Christmas 1940, when the interior was destroyed by fire.

In 1951, the Revd Cyril Armitage was appointed to the burnt-out ruins. Together with Architect Godfrey Allen and financial support from the Fleet Street newspaper and print industries, he helped raise the new church of St Bride's from the ashes. The building was restored to Wren's original designs, with clear leaded windows, Portland stone columns and arches, and 221 individually carved and

gilded roses. The furnishings were redesigned, inspired by other Wren interiors.

On the east wall is a celestial choir, painted in 1957 by artist Glyn Jones as a trompe l'oeil, based on an image recorded in the Wren church.

At the west end are statues of St Bride and St Paul by David McFall and Wren's fine minstrels' gallery, which now houses part of the organ, with its 4,000 pipes hidden from view. Above rises the famous spire, which inspired the design of the first elaborate multi-tiered wedding cake.

Rebuilding the church was not just about the physical building. Cyril Armitage re-established the Guild of St Bride, first formed in the 14th century, giving its members a sense of purpose and duty. The Guild continues to provide a valuable welcome and hospitality to visitors.

A new choir was also formed, with 12 professional singers of an exceptional standard. This tradition continues, with the choir singing two services every Sunday, as well as weddings and memorial services, many for journalists and those connected with the industry.

Above all, St Bride's continues to be open to all as a place of prayer and worship, whether for Choral Eucharist, Choral Evensong, weekday silence, or simply as a place of refuge from the challenges of the city.